

**BLACK SEASON** Artisans at work at a handicrafts exhibition organised by the state government in Srinagar in October

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▶ KASHMIR

# RUINED BY STATECRAFT

**It's a bleak Christmas as Trump's tariffs take a toll on Kashmir's handicrafts exports sector. Artisans see business plunging by two-thirds in peak season**

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**IT'S NOT JUST A SNOW-WHITE LANDSCAPE** that joins Kashmir with countries in the northern latitudes during Christmas season. There's always been a buzzing trail of commerce—conveying sledfuls of Kashmiri handicrafts to Christmas markets out West. But this centuries-old romance has hit its bleakest chapter this year. As festive demand peaks across the US and Europe, that flow of goodies—from tiny papier-mâché trinkets to exquisite carpets and pashmina—has slowed to a trickle.

The culprit? Think of an antonym for Santa Claus, the giver of gifts. Yes, it's Donald Trump and his 50 per cent tariffs on Indian goods, which compounded the damage already inflicted by the Russia-Ukraine and Israel-Gaza wars. For Kashmir's artisans, the twin shocks amount to what one craftsman calls "a doomsday scenario".

"There's an 80 per cent slump in sales," says Ali Mohammad Shirazi, a 67-year-old Srinagar exporter whose family has traded Kashmiri crafts since 1945. "Orders that usually arrived months before Christmas have dried up. Even previous shipments are stuck, and payments delayed."

The peak shopping season of Christmas across the West accounts for nearly 70 per cent of Kashmir's annual papier mache exports. That waxing graph has not just waned this year—it's been walloped. Shirazi's firm, Rian Impax, saw sales crash from Rs 3.5 crore in 2023 to under Rs 1 crore this year. "We're at the bottom of the price ladder and live in penury," says Tariq Zaz, an artisan in Srinagar's Lal Bazar. "There are few orders this year. It's creeping in on our survival."

## CATASTROPHIC COLLAPSE

Survival is not a word used loosely here. Look at the numbers. Kashmir's overall handicraft exports, which stood at Rs 2,175 crore in 2014-15, fell to Rs 1,162 crore by 2023-24. This year has seen a catastrophic collapse to Rs 733 crore, according to official data. That's a two-third slump from a decade ago—